

English Language Supports

Purpose:

To provide culturally and linguistically diverse learners with equitable access to cohesive learning opportunities that accelerate their social and academic English, provide meaningful access to grade level content, and increase their overall achievement through collaboration and co-teaching.

Best Practices for Instruction of English Learners:

- BEST PRACTICE #1: **Understand and address the academic language demands of the lesson**
 - Academic language demands are the ways in which students use language (i.e., reading, writing, listening, and speaking) in academic settings to participate in learning tasks and demonstrate their learning. Specifically, academic language demands encompass language features at the word, sentence, and discourse levels and language functions, or the communicative purposes of using language (e.g., explaining, justifying, inferring, seeking information, informing).
 - Helping students identify and understand academic language demands benefits both students' language development and conceptual learning. For ELs, conceptual learning and language development go hand-in-hand. As ELs are learning content, they are learning language, and vice versa. Attending to academic language demands requires teachers and ELs to understand how each language feature and function work together to convey meaning about discipline-specific concepts and content.
- BEST PRACTICE #2: **Build upon students' linguistic & cultural funds of knowledge**
 - EL students have diverse backgrounds and differ in home and academic language, prior educational experiences, and cultural resources, or funds of knowledge. Students' backgrounds are rich sources of information that teachers can build upon to make instruction relevant and meaningful. Teachers who adopt this asset-based approach to learning and teaching recognize the value in students' home and community experiences in addition to their prior academic knowledge. They design learning opportunities that build upon students' linguistic and cultural funds of knowledge to enhance instruction, increase students' interest, participation and learning, and improve teacher-student relationships.
 - When designing instruction for ELs, teachers should consider and expand upon how the instructional task at hand can be linked to students' funds of knowledge and prior educational experiences, content knowledge, and language development.
- BEST PRACTICE #3: **Design and scaffold learning opportunities in every lesson that integrate listening, speaking, reading, and writing domains**
 - ELs require access to meaningful and challenging tasks. While students may require language supports to access lesson tasks, care must be taken in

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maintaining task quality and rigor. Too often, the language and conceptual demands of activities used for ELs are simplified to a level that leaves little opportunity for ELs to learn new content, develop new conceptual and linguistic understandings, and demonstrate their progress. Teachers can maintain the rigor of the tasks by tightly integrating all four language domains and incorporating domain-specific scaffolding techniques.

- Teachers should design tasks that integrate reading, writing, listening, and speaking activities for the purpose of making meaning of content knowledge and language. All ELs, regardless of language proficiency, benefit from engagement in activities that require them to make use of oral and print-based literacy skills as the development of one domain is dependent on the other three.
- **BEST PRACTICE #4: Provide opportunities for student participation through meaningful discourse and structured collaboration**
 - ELs demonstrate their learning through discourse - structured teaching and learning interactions. When ELs engage in discourse, they work with peers to solve a problem, construct an explanation, provide a justification, build on the ideas of others, or express their thinking during a learning activity. Collaborative opportunities for ELs are particularly important. ELs use language to construct meaning, show content understanding, and develop language. Teachers gather evidence of content and language learning by strategically designing opportunities for discourse and collaboration.
 - Teachers consider the types of groupings that would best support ELs. Groupings could range from (a) pair to small to whole group, (b) heterogeneous to mixed to homogeneous English language proficiency levels, or (c) heterogeneous to mixed to homogeneous home languages.